



FREE Yourself

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**802.11 is here to stay.
For all who missed
the bandwagon we
present the means to
connected freedom.**

To most users Wi-Fi is a buzzword...the kind that everybody uses and wants a piece of. Unfortunately, IEEE 802.11 (the proper name for Wi-Fi and interchangeably used hereon) is a phrase that is most often misunderstood or at best, poorly understood. At Digit, we're believers in the goodness of 802.11, but most of our readers aren't – if the mails and calls we receive are an indication. A general consensus is 802.11 is mostly for technology buffs with very little real world advantages. After all, good old RJ45 (wired LAN) is still faster right? Not to mention the multitude of security concerns. An allied technology WiMAX (also called IEEE 802.16) has become the darling of urban internet service providers (ISPs) in India. Although 802.11 finds many a fan in the corporate fraternity, its adoption in households has

been painfully slow.

One myth we'd like to bust right now is that Wi-Fi networks aren't secure – this is hogwash. With adequate caution, a half-decent wireless router and the correct settings, a wireless network is as impregnable as a wired one. In terms of speed, Wi-Fi is still a good bit away from RJ45 speeds; but, things have gotten faster the last time we checked. The fact is no household internet connection in this country delivers even 20 per cent the bandwidth that a wireless connection provides. So if you feel that a wireless access point will bottleneck your download speeds, think again. For other users Wi-Fi is a hassle to set up and a bigger hassle to secure. Quirks still abound, but setups and security features have been simplified. One of the major assets this technology has, and one we cannot deny, is convenience of use. Wireless internet browsing on a single internet connection for all devices including desktops,

notebooks, PDAs, phones and even Wi-Fi-enabled PMPs; the possibilities are virtually limitless.

We tested 24 wireless devices. Five out of these were ADSL routers that come with RJ11 (telephone) connects for internet. There were 18 routers and one access point. An access point simply accepts a wired connection and passes on a wireless connection – it has no routing abilities. We had the biggest brands and some of the finest models in the global market. Among the people who did not participate were ASUS, Gigabyte and MSI. These brands are not selling Wi-Fi devices in the market at the time of this test. Level One is another well known brand we contacted, but they didn't seem too keen on participation for unknown reasons.

ADSL routers

A few service providers still offer internet access via telephone lines and when you purchase such a connection a modem is required. An ADSL router does

